



STAR TURNS:
Zinta weeps,
Shah Rukh is
mobbed, Akshay
Kumar performs,
Gautam Gambhir
goes to work

HOME

The TAM ratings for the IPL's first three matches beat the highest rated TV shows of that week and matched the World T20 figures

THE SHOW STOPPERS*

Programme	TVR
<i>Chote Ustaad</i> , Star Plus	4.7
<i>Banoo Main Teri Dulhan</i> , Zee	4.2
<i>Bidayi</i> , Star Plus (April 3)	4.1
<i>Bidayi</i> , Star Plus (April 2)	3.9

WORLD T20 RECORDS

Match	TVR
India vs Pakistan final	10.5
India vs Aust semi-final	9.8
India vs England	6.6
India vs Pak group game	5.3

*TAM ratings are for the week ended April 5, based on viewership in 148 centres. Ratings for the IPL matches above are TAM ratings for April 18 and 19 based on findings from six major metros—Delhi, Mumbai, Bangalore, Kolkata, Chennai, Hyderabad.

ted, "All franchises are struggling to sell tickets. People would rather watch on television—it's inexpensive and convenient." He reckons the most any team has actually sold, contrary to claims, is 15 per cent of capacity. The ticketing fiasco and the zero merchandise earnings cause one insider to say, "Owners could regret their expenses when the real numbers hit them in the face two months from now."

Yet team bosses could well decide that the upside of being involved in the IPL—networking, brand-building, visibility and what one franchise member termed, "ego satisfaction"—far outweighs trivialities like profit and loss.

Perched above this high-volume festival of excess and instant gratifica-

tion is the BCCI, which insists the IPL would benefit grassroots cricket through infrastructure upgradation.

The average spectator in Kolkata, though, found himself in the same old Eden Gardens with drinking water hard to come by. Vikram Dayal, CEO of sports management company Sporting Excellence, says the multimillion dollar player auction led spectators to rightly expect that franchise owners would improve stadium facilities.

The day after Mumbai's first home game, Dayal received an email from one of his clients, a multinational CEO which read, "Went yesterday. Very crappily organised. No scoreboard on ground. Chaos on food. Too hot. Can't see myself/clients finding this exciting even from an

THE NUMBERS GAME

The **IPL** opening match got 12.5 mn viewers. But there's room for huge growth. The World T-20 India-Pak final reached **23 mn** viewers.

Women formed **36%** of the audience for the IPL's first three matches, as compared to **64%** men.

38% of the IPL audience was above 35, the next highest segment was the 15-24 age group making up **27%**.

AC room." Dayal says, "The IPL should concentrate on bridging the promise-delivery gap before it's too late, which will be sad for all stakeholders."

Raman realises the real stuff will have to kick in soon. "The entertainment alone is not going to sustain the IPL," he says, "the cricket has to sustain it from now on." Ah, yes after Shah Rukh, Preity, the cheerleaders, it is useful to remember that cricket is, in fact, the IPL's reason for being. It will succeed if the audience sees players busting their guts in closely contested games.

The IPL's hype and salaries have had their effect. McCullum admitted his legs were shaking as he took guard in the Bangalore opener. The impressive credentials of teammates like Sourav